

Article Summary and Opinion

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Name of Article	Psychosis and Mass Shootings: A Systematic Examination Using Publicly Available Data
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Article Authors	Jillian K. Peterson, James A. Densley, Kyle Knapp, Stasia Higgins, and Amanda Jensen
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Summary

In their work Peterson, Densley, Knapp, Higgins, and Jensen addressed an issue that gets repeated again and again after nearly every mass shooting occurs in the United States. That issue is whether mental illness causes mass shootings. Rather than asking whether shooters had a diagnosis (as earlier research has done), the researchers asked a more limited and useful question. How often did symptoms of psychosis (e.g., delusions or hallucinations) cause the shooting? Also, how do shooters motivated by psychosis compare to other shooters? The research utilized The Violence Project database. The Violence Project database is federally funded and accessible to the public. It includes data on 172 perpetrators of 168 mass public shootings that occurred between 1966 and 2020. The authors utilized the Congressional Research Service definition of mass public shooting. A mass public shooting is defined as four or more individuals being killed with firearms in a public location. The definition excludes shootings related to gang violence, robbery, or private family disputes. The researchers coded 166 life-history variables for each shooter using court records, manifestos, interviews, news archives, and other open-source material. Each case was reviewed independently by several coders. Regarding psychosis specifically, the researchers used a four-point scale developed from earlier research on offenders with mental illness. The four-point scale ranged from no role to major role. If psychosis played a major role in motivating the shooting, the shooter was acting upon delusions or hallucinations while planning and carrying out the attack and there was no other apparent motivation for the act. The results indicated that psychosis played no role whatsoever in approximately 70 percent of the shootings. Psychosis played a small role in 11 percent of the shootings; psychosis played a medium role in approximately 9 percent of the shootings; and psychosis played a large role in approximately 10 percent of the shootings.

Overall, psychosis served as the primary motivation for approximately one case in every ten and contributed to some extent in approximately three cases out of every ten. The percentages remained relatively consistent over five decades.

Additionally, mental health history in general terms was present in a majority of shooters. Approximately 60 percent of shooters possessed some form of documented mental health history (hospitalizations, counseling, medications, etc.). Approximately 25 percent of shooters exhibited evidence of a psychotic disorder, which is significantly higher than the occurrence rate in the general population. The authors demonstrate that history and motivation are distinct entities. Possessing a diagnosis in one's past does not necessarily indicate that symptoms were responsible for motivating the attack. When comparing shooters motivated by psychosis to shooters motivated by something else, they were virtually identical. Statistically speaking there were no significant differences between the groups based on age, race, criminal record, history of violent behavior, drug usage, employment status, or relationship status. The only statistically significant difference between the groups was education level; specifically, shooters motivated by psychosis were more likely to have attended college. Similarly, firearm-related behaviors were similar between the groups. Handguns were the most commonly used weapon type. Most guns were obtained lawfully. More than half of all firearms used by shooters with previous psychiatric hospitalizations were obtained lawfully. The authors interpret this information as an indication that the federal prohibition on firearm sales to individuals who have been involuntarily committed is functioning improperly. Based upon these findings, the authors argue that psychosis is a poor indicator of potential dangerousness.

Therefore, policymakers should focus on creating laws designed to address dangerous situations and behaviors. Examples provided by the authors include background checks, extreme risk protection orders, recovery systems designed to remove firearms from owners who become prohibited after purchasing them, and school/workplace threat assessment teams that function more like crisis response units than disciplinary committees. The authors also suggest that fame-seeking and hatred often motivate mass shootings. As such, they advocate for responses such as restricting media use of perpetrator names.

Opinion

I appreciate that this article does not provide a definitive answer regarding the relationship between mental illness and mass shootings.

For example, it would have been easy for the authors to report the 70 percent figure and state that mental illness is irrelevant to mass shootings or report the 60 percent mental health history figure and support the common narrative. Instead, the authors demonstrate that both are simultaneously valid truths. This demonstrates a more accurate representation than most news articles provide.

Although I believe that relying on public records should receive more consideration from the authors than they provide, I agree that public record usage represents limitations. Media coverage is often inconsistent; the authors themselves present evidence indicating that reporters tend to portray White shooters as mentally ill more frequently than Black shooters; and some diagnoses were established only after an individual was arrested.

Therefore, the estimate of psychotic disorder prevalence may be inaccurate in either direction; additionally, without a comparison group of other violent offenders, it remains unclear how unusual a 27 percent rate is within this cohort.

Although the authors acknowledge these limitations, I believe they could influence interpretations more than their discussions admit.

However, the policy recommendations presented by the authors represent why this article is relevant to a law journal. The finding that previously hospitalized shooters legally purchased most of their firearms represents an identifiable deficiency in current law rather than merely reflecting public perception. This finding supports improving reporting mechanisms and implementing additional background check requirements, both of which are more practical goals than attempting to predict which individuals among millions of Americans with mental illnesses will commit violent acts.